relook at political and organisational strategy are getting louder. Where this goes in the days ahead could significantly impact the future of Akhilesh and Chaudhary as well as Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, who led the Congress campaign in the state.

In the initial disappointment with the election results, despite the SP increasing its seat tally by two-and-a-half times, many of its leaders had put the blame on EVM tampering. But Akhilesh's formerly estranged uncle Shivpal Singh Yadav, who won the Jaswantnagar seat with a margin of 90,979 votes, struck a different note—he made it a point to say that the presence of VVPAT (Voter Verified Paper Audit Trail) makes such tampering unlikely. He also said that opposition parties should focus instead on organisation-building, besides well-planned ticket distribution, if they want to defeat the BJP—a not-so-veiled critique of his nephew's perceived aloofness during peacetime.



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

Some SP leaders worry about what being out of power for another five years could do to the morale of party workers. Another key issue being discussed—and no one will miss the significance—is the need to prepare a second rung of leadership. "That's what we should focus on now," says a senior leader who didn't want to be identified. "Most of us were expecting victory in this election, but somewhere we are lagging behind. We should understand where we went wrong." According to this leader, it's high time the SP went beyond its image of being a Muslim-Yadav party. "We must rework our strategy," he says.

Agreeing on the need for a second line of leaders, another senior functionary says, "As a star campaigner, we have only Akhileshji. He has to handle the whole party and also ticket distribution. He is our face in the media and also represents the party in the Lok Sabha. How much can one leader do?" The senior functionary adds that Shivpal and other experienced leaders must have a greater role. "Shivpal floated his own party, but he is still an asset for us," he says.

But striking someone who's down is an old game in politics, and Akhilesh may be able to tide over things with enough ease. With SP's vote share rising to 32.06 per cent in this election from 21.8 per cent in 2017, and its seat tally going up to 111 from 47, spokesperson Ashutosh Verma says the party plans to build on it and move forward.

The RLD, meanwhile, may have the dubious distinction of witnessing the biggest gap between expectation and performance. Its leaders had moved with a degree of certitude before the election, riding as they were on the farmers' agitation, but the party ended up with just eight seats out of the 33 it contested, with a vote share of 2.85 per cent. But the loyalists are holding on for now. Dismissing Masood's allegations against the party leadership as "baseless and false", RLD spokesperson Anupam Mishra says, "He resigned because he did not get a ticket. We have full respect for Jayantji, and we will continue to support him in his decisions."

But introspection is carrying on apace. "The results were disappointing. We were expecting at least 20

CHALLENGES

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- The grand old party cannot bank primarily on Priyanka Gandhi's brand value and needs to focus on organisation-building
- Leaders have to look at forging some tactical understanding with SP and RLD to avoid splitting of opposition votes

"THE OPPOSITION SHOULD LEARN FROM THE BJP'S STYLE OF BOOTH-LEVEL ORGANISATION BUILDING," SAYS FORMER LUCKNOW UNIVERSITY PROFESSOR S.K. DWIVEDI